



Ethics and Your Career

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WHAT'S COVERED

In this lesson, you will learn how to apply ethical theory to your own professional brand and personal future. Specifically, this lesson will cover:

1. Finding the "Right Fit"
2. It's Not About the Money—Is It?
3. The Role of Ethical Top Leadership

1. Finding the "Right Fit"

Ethics has become a major consideration for people in their selection of work and career. The following observation about young British workers applies to their counterparts in the United States, as well: “There’s a quiet revolution happening . . . but it’s not about pay, hours or contracts. It’s a coup d’état (violent takeover) led by the nation’s young, politically engaged jobseekers who demand employers enshrine values and ethics in their business model, not just profit” (Jenkin, 2015).

Many job seekers want to feel that what they are doing is not just making money but making a difference—that is, contributing to the company in unique ways that reflect their core values, conscience, and personality. They believe an individual has worth beyond his or her immediate work or position. Many modern companies thus try to give greater weight to the human cost of decisions and employee happiness. They know that, according to studies, employees in “companies that work to build and maintain ethical workplace cultures are more financially successful and have more motivated, productive employees.” The decision whether to transfer someone from Boston to Salt Lake City, for instance, would now likely include the employee from the beginning and consider the impact on family members and the employee’s future, in addition to the needs of the company. Historically, such orders might be made without any consideration of the employee’s desires, needs, or family. The only options for the employee would be to accept the transfer or resign.

There are several reasons for the change. The first is that satisfied employees are more productive and feel greater commitment to the organization, and organizations in turn understand this better. Second, there are more options for job seekers in many fields, which gives them more freedom to choose a company for which to work. A third reason more companies are considering what truly makes employees happy is that even more

than loyalty, employees appear to value the freedom and responsibility to have moral agency in their own lives. Remember that moral agency is being able to adhere to your own sense of right and wrong; this also entails a willingness to be held accountable for your choices.



DID YOU KNOW

Many business journals report annually on how highly employees rate their workplaces. For example, you can consult *Fortune*'s annual list of "100 Best Companies to Work For," which you can search by such factors as diversity, compensation, and paid time off. You can also consult specialized lists such as *Forbes*'s "100 Best Workplaces for Women" and *Black Enterprise*'s "50 Best Companies for Diversity." Potential employees consider an organization by evaluating many factors, including reputation and work climate. The exercise of moral agency includes making a judgment about the alignment of personal and corporate conscience. Rather than jumping at the first job offer, moral agents assess whether the values expressed by the organization conform with their own, while recognizing that there is no perfect job. Even the most ethical organizations make mistakes, and even the most corrupt have managers and workers of integrity. This is why the "right fit" is more likely to be a job in which you can grow or that itself will change in a way that allows you to find greater meaning in it. Given you spend a large part of your life at work, it is important to consider what is your life's work. What you dedicate your time, energy, and effort to across your lifetime counts. Why you do something is as important a consideration as what you do or how you do it.



BRAINSTORM

Most job interviews either begin or end with an opportunity for you to ask questions. This is your chance to ask about the code of ethics at a workplace, and the topics most interesting to you. For example, you may ask what the organization has done to achieve equity, minimize their carbon footprint, or invest in the community. Write a series of questions that you can ask but be sure to modify the question based on what you learn before or during the interview. Also be sincere in your questions—this is your chance to show the interviewer that you have a personal code of ethics you want to live by, but it will be counterproductive if the question feels false.

2. It's Not About the Money—Is It?

You may follow a professional vocation that offers low pay or low status but yields nontangible rewards, such as nonprofit work or teaching at a charter school. Or you may find a position in a for-profit company that pays a great deal and offers job security but leaves you feeling unhappy or unfulfilled. The point is that positions with high compensation and a certain stature do not always infuse their holders with the greatest psychological and emotional rewards, and it is different for each of us. In the best of all worlds, you might embark on a well-paying career that helps others or contributes a much-needed good or service to society. Finding such work is easier said than done, of course, because the aim of most jobs is not to help people find meaning or happiness. Where these do occur, they are often ancillary effects of work, whose real purpose is the profitability without which there would not be any jobs at all.

Also consider the gap between the purpose of the business and the purpose of the individuals in it. Except in a few startups, these purposes are not identical. Even artists, musicians, and independent practitioners who

derive great meaning from their work are not immune to the frustrations over money or career that affect everyone else.

It has been estimated, however, that the amount of money needed to be happy is not actually that much, at least by Western standards, although it is well above the poverty line. Most people find themselves somewhere in the middle in terms of satisfaction and pay. Finding the proper balance between the two for you is taking a step on the way to your growth as a professional. You will make that assessment not once but throughout your career as you move in and out of jobs. Even if it turns out to be the best decision of your life, the choice to work for a company because of its mission, leadership, or cultural values should be intentional and based on sufficient knowledge of the company and yourself. To be appreciated for your contributions in the workplace, to work with congenial colleagues, or to provide a product or service of which you are proud might rival money as your most **intrinsic motivator** at work. An intrinsic motivator is a motivation that comes from within you, such as pride, while **extrinsic motivators** are those things provided to you, such as pay. Studies attest to intrinsic motivators being important and, as professionals of integrity, you must decide for yourself how strong a benefit salary alone is in the job or company you select.



REFLECT

What are your biggest intrinsic motivators? Do you like challenges? Recognition? The feeling that you are doing good in the world? Or is your main motivation (besides pay) simply the relationships you develop at work? Understanding your intrinsic motivators and finding the job that provides them is as important to long-term contentment as compensation.



TERMS TO KNOW

Intrinsic Motivator

Motivation that comes from within you, such as pride or ambition.

Extrinsic Motivator

Motivation that is provided to you, primarily compensation.

3. The Role of Ethical Top Leadership

As you consider your future path, perhaps leading toward a leadership role, keep in mind that perhaps the most effective way ethical behavior is learned in a company is through the modeling of that behavior by senior executives and others in leadership positions. This modeling sets what is known as “tone at the top.” Employees may already have a personal moral code when they join an organization, but when they see key figures in the workplace actually living out the ethical values of the company, they are more likely to follow suit and take ethics seriously. Leaders’ ethical behavior is especially important in emerging fields like artificial intelligence, where questions of safety, bias, misuse of technology, and privacy are raised daily. It is not enough to offer codes of conduct, training, reporting, and review programs, no matter how thorough or sophisticated, if management does not adhere to or promote them. These are tools rather than solutions. The solutions come from leaders using the tools and showing others how to do the same. This takes practice, reinforcement, and collaboration at all levels of an organization. The result will be a culture of ethics that permeates the company from top to bottom.



What do you admire most in a leader? Think about the bosses, teachers, coaches, and relatives who have set a good example of leadership in your life, and what qualities they had that made them effective leaders.

IN CONTEXT

Bill Swanson, former CEO of the defense contractor Raytheon, became well known for publishing a booklet entitled *Swanson's Unwritten Rules of Management*, which included thirty-three brief maxims for achieving success in business and cultivating a virtuous life in the corporate world. The list included items like the famous "Waiter Rule," which held that you can judge a person's character by the way they treat those in subservient positions.

Swanson was hailed as a sage of modern business whose rules had saved companies like Czar Entertainment and Panera Bread from making bad hiring decisions. Then it was discovered that he had plagiarized the list from several sources. The booklet was discontinued, and Swanson's compensation and retirement package was modified downward. As in similar cases of ethical lapse, however, the greatest damage was to his reputation, despite an otherwise distinguished 42-year career.

Ethics matter not merely because acting unethically will end in a compliance problem or public relations nightmare but because ethics is a way of life, not a hurdle to overcome. Moreover, the benefit of ethical behavior can grow over time so that a company begins to attract other ethical professionals and develops a reputation for honesty, integrity, and dependability. In a globally competitive world, these are not inconsequential factors. In an ethical workplace, employee satisfaction creates more loyalty to the company, and morale improves because employees and managers feel they are part of an effort they can be proud of. Business performance picks up in ways ranging from higher earnings per share to increased customer retention to more satisfied employees. Conversely, unethical actions and poor management may quickly end up published on the web, causing potential employees to take a second look, or to look elsewhere.

You do not have to choose between ethics and profits; many of the companies with high ethical reputations also consistently pay dividends to investors, such as companies like UPS, Xerox, 3M, and IBM. Notice the staying power of these two companies as well. Each is more than a century old and has a global presence. To test the consumer confidence these corporations evoke, consider your own opinion of how reputable they are. Ask your friends and family, too. That makes them highly attractive as places to work, with job security and room for advancement.

Again, employee loyalty, a positive work environment, and strong financial performance are not accidents; they are the result of intentional efforts on the part of leadership and board members who provide an ethical vision and a plan for execution to all stakeholders. Ethical business need not be a **zero-sum game**, a situation where one can only win if the other side loses. There are opportunities to find outcomes in which everyone wins. Is there a more attractive environment for those just starting out in their careers? To be part of something profitable, responsible, and individually uplifting justifies all the work required to get there.



TERM TO KNOW

Zero-Sum Game

A situation where there must be a winner and a loser.



SUMMARY

In this lesson, you learned about **finding the right fit** for you ethically as you choose which company to work for. You learned business **cannot only be about the money**, or profit, or the bottom line, as ethical actions and corporate responsibility are increasingly a factor in purchasing decisions. From customers to potential employees to existing employees, how a business operates directly impacts its success. This begins with **ethical leaders acting as role models**. Ethical actions are an important part of business decisions and your personal decisions regarding your career.

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TERMS TO KNOW

Extrinsic Motivators

Motivation that comes from external sources, such as compensation.

Intrinsic Motivators

Motivation that comes from within you, such as pride.

Zero-Sum Game

A situation where there must be a winner and a loser.